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RESEARCH REPORT

Fleet Composition of a Mediterranean Day-Charter Operation: A Case Study

An empirical analysis of length, capacity, vessel type and pricing structure across an 18-boat Costa del Sol charter fleet

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Abstract

This paper examines the fleet composition of a single Mediterranean day-charter operation based at Puerto Banus, on Spain's Costa del Sol. Using the operator's own published fleet record of 18 vessels, we analyse four structural dimensions: length overall, guest capacity, vessel typology and pricing tier. The fleet spans 6.4 metres to 29 metres in length, a range of more than four to one, and carries from 5 to 12 guests per vessel, with a combined seated capacity of 176 guests across the 18 hulls. The mean length is 16.7 metres against a median of 13.25 metres, a gap that signals a right-skewed distribution in which a cluster of small day boats and mid-size cruisers is balanced by a tail of large superyachts. Vessel types resolve into 11 distinct categories, with luxury motor yachts the single largest group at five hulls. Builder provenance is dominated by Italian marques, led by Overmarine with three Mangusta 80 hulls. Pricing is published transparently for only a minority of the fleet, with 13 of 18 vessels quoted on request and 5 carrying fixed tariffs. We argue that the fleet is best understood not as a uniform product line but as a deliberately tiered ladder, engineered to convert a single departure port into a wide span of price points, party sizes and use cases, from a licence-free entry boat at 230 euros for two hours to an all-inclusive 26-metre superyacht at 9,500 euros for six. Every figure in this paper traces to the operator's fleet data and published price tiers.

Background, Data and Method

Marbella and its marina district of Puerto Banus form one of the densest leisure-boating markets in the western Mediterranean. The shoreline runs from Estepona and Sotogrande in the west, past the Golden Mile and Marbella town, to Cabopino in the east, with the Strait of Gibraltar a long day's cruise to the south-west. Within this compact operating area a charter fleet does not need range so much as it needs variety, because the customer base divides into many small segments: families wanting a calm half-day, groups marking a celebration, anglers heading offshore, and high-end clients seeking a flagship for the day. The fleet studied here is a direct response to that segmentation.

Our data source is the operator's structured fleet record, which lists 18 vessels and, for each, a name, builder, vessel type, length overall in metres, guest capacity, departure port, pricing tier and a descriptive summary. Alongside the per-vessel records sits a schedule of price tiers and a list of shared inclusions that apply across the catered fleet. These two artefacts, the vessel list and the tier schedule, are the entirety of the quantitative evidence used here. Where we report a length, a capacity, a price or a count, it is drawn directly from those records. Where we add context about a shipyard's history or a cruising itinerary, that is general background and is flagged as such rather than presented as a measured specification.

The method is descriptive statistics and classification, not new measurement. We tabulate the 18 vessels along each structural dimension, compute simple summary statistics, group the hulls into length bands and type families, and read the pricing tiers against capacity to infer the operator's market positioning. Two caveats apply. First, this is a single-operator case study, so the patterns we find describe one fleet's commercial design rather than the Costa del Sol market as a whole. Second, lengths are nominal figures as

published, and several models carry shorthand names whose numeric badge does not equal the recorded metre length, a point we return to when discussing typology.

SECTION 03

The Length Distribution

Length overall is the single most informative variable in a charter fleet, because it correlates with almost everything a customer cares about: deck space, stability, cruising comfort, crew complement and price. The 18 vessels in this fleet range from the 6.4-metre Mariah SX21 bowrider to the 29-metre Ferretti 94, a span of 22.6 metres. The arithmetic mean length is 16.7 metres, but the median is markedly lower at 13.25 metres. Whenever the mean sits well above the median, the distribution is skewed to the right, and that is exactly what we find here: a dense body of small and mid-size craft, with a thinner upper tail of large yachts pulling the average upward.

Grouping the hulls into 5-metre length bands makes the shape explicit. The table below shows the count of vessels in each band.

LENGTH BAND	VESSELS	SHARE OF FLEET	EXAMPLES
Under 10 m	3	17%	Mariah SX21 (6.4 m), Speedboat (7 m), Dubhe (8 m)
10 to 15 m	7	39%	Red Tide (11 m), Lagoon 380 (11.6 m), Astondoa 40 (12.5 m), Pershing 46 (14 m)
15 to 20 m	1	6%	Azimut 58 Flybridge (17.6 m)
20 to 25 m	4	22%	Mangusta 80 hulls and K80 (all 24 m)
25 m and over	3	17%	Canados 86 (26 m), Maiora 26m (26 m), Ferretti 94 (29 m)

The 10-to-15-metre band is the fleet's centre of gravity, holding 7 of 18 hulls, or 39 per cent. This is the classic Mediterranean day-charter size: large enough for a real saloon, a flybridge or a sun-pad and a private cabin, yet small enough to be handled by a single skipper and priced within reach of a group splitting the cost. Notably, the 15-to-20-metre band is nearly empty, with the 17.6-metre Azimut 58 its only occupant. The fleet therefore has a visible gap between its mid-size cruisers and its large yachts, jumping from 14 metres to 17.6 metres and then to 24 metres. That gap is commercially logical: the 24-metre class is where the product changes character, from a skipper-only day boat to a crewed flagship, and the operator has chosen to concentrate inventory on either side of the transition rather than within it.



♦ The 11.6-metre Lagoon 380, the fleet's only sailing catamaran, sits squarely in the 10-to-15-metre band that holds 39 per cent of the hulls.

SECTION 04

Capacity and the Economics of Seats

Guest capacity is the second structural axis, and in a day-charter business it is the axis closest to revenue, because a chartered boat is sold by the hull rather than by the seat. The 18 vessels carry between 5 and 12 guests each. The mean capacity is 9.8 guests and the median is 10.5, and the combined seated capacity of the whole fleet is 176 guests. Capacity is far more tightly bunched than length: where length spans a factor of more than four, capacity spans a factor of only 2.4, from 5 to 12.

The reason for that compression is regulatory and practical rather than physical. Many Mediterranean day-charter vessels are certified for 12 guests, a threshold above which heavier commercial passenger rules apply, and a large share of this fleet sits exactly at that ceiling. Every vessel of 17.6 metres and above in the fleet carries precisely 12 guests: the Azimut 58, all four 24-metre boats, the two 26-metre superyachts and the 29-metre Ferretti. A 29-metre Ferretti and a 17.6-metre Azimut thus sell the same number of seats, even though the Ferretti offers vastly more space, crew and amenity per guest. This is the central economic fact of the upper fleet: above a certain size, customers are not buying more seats, they are buying more space, comfort and prestige around the same 12 people.

At the small end, capacity is constrained differently. The 8-metre Dubhe and the 6.4-metre Mariah SX21 each carry 5 guests, and the 7-metre Speedboat and 11-metre Red Tide fishing boat carry 6. Here the limit is genuinely about deck space and licence category rather than the 12-guest commercial threshold. The table below pairs capacity against length for the full fleet, sorted by length, and shows how the two variables diverge.

VESSEL	LENGTH (M)	CAPACITY	GUESTS PER METRE
Mariah SX21	6.4	5	0.78
Speedboat	7	6	0.86
Dubhe	8	5	0.63
Red Tide	11	6	0.55
Bandido	11.5	8	0.70
Lagoon 380	11.6	10	0.86
Fairline Targa 12m	12	10	0.83
Astondoa 40	12.5	9	0.72
Azimut 39	12.5	11	0.88
Pershing 46	14	10	0.71
Azimut 58 Flybridge	17.6	12	0.68
Mangusta 80 / K80 (x4)	24	12	0.50
Canados 86	26	12	0.46
Maiora 26m	26	12	0.46
Ferretti 94	29	12	0.41

The guests-per-metre column falls steadily as length rises, from 0.78 to 0.88 on the small craft down to 0.41 on the 29-metre Ferretti. Read another way, the larger the yacht, the more boat each guest commands. The 11.6-metre Lagoon 380 catamaran is a revealing outlier: at 0.86 guests per metre it packs in seats as densely as boats half its category, because a catamaran's twin hulls and wide bridgedeck create a flat, broad platform that carries 10 guests in a length where a monohull of the same metre count carries 8 or 9. Stability and deck area, not waterline length, drive a catamaran's capacity.

SECTION 05

Vessel Typology

The fleet record assigns each vessel to a named type, and those names resolve into 11 distinct categories across 18 hulls. That is an unusually fine-grained typology for a single fleet, and it reflects a deliberate strategy of covering every recognisable day-charter use case rather than standardising on one or two hull forms. The categories, in order of count, are: luxury motor yacht (5 vessels), then four two-vessel families,

namely motor yacht, sport yacht, luxury sport yacht and a sport-fishing pair, and finally seven single-vessel categories including flybridge motor yacht, sailing catamaran, day boat, bowrider and speedboat.

The luxury motor yacht is the fleet's flagship category, with five hulls: the original Mangusta 80 known as Nina, the K80, the Canados 86, the Maiora 26m and the Ferretti 94. If the two further Mangusta 80 hulls badged as luxury sport yachts are added, the broad superyacht-class grouping reaches seven vessels, more than a third of the fleet. This concentration tells us where the operator sees its differentiated value: any number of competitors can supply a 12-metre cruiser, but a deep bench of 24-to-29-metre flagships is rarer and harder to replicate, and it is what lets the operation claim the largest day-charter yacht in the market.

The middle of the fleet is the sport-and-motor-yacht zone. Two pure motor yachts, the Spanish-built Astondoa 40 and the Italian Azimut 39, sit at 12.5 metres and anchor the catered entry tier. Two sport yachts, the British Fairline Targa 12m and the Italian Pershing 46, add speed and style at 12 and 14 metres. These four are the fleet's volume cruisers: comfortable, single-skipper boats for a group of nine to eleven on a half-day or full-day out.

The remaining categories each fill a specific niche. The Lagoon 380 is the fleet's only sailing vessel and its only catamaran, the choice for guests prone to seasickness or wanting a flat platform. Two sport-fishing craft, the Bandido and the purpose-built Red Tide, serve the offshore angling segment with outriggers, rod holders and livewells. At the entry level the Dubhe day boat, the Mariah SX21 bowrider and the generic Speedboat cover short, fast, low-cost outings. One point of caution on naming: several models carry numeric badges that are not their metric length. The Astondoa 40, Azimut 39, Pershing 46, Azimut 58, Canados 86, Fairline Targa 12m and Ferretti 94 use a mix of imperial-foot conventions and model-line numbers, so the badge should never be read as the recorded metre length, which is the figure used throughout this analysis.



♦ The Maiora 26m, one of five luxury motor yachts that form the fleet's flagship category and more than a third of all hulls when both Mangusta variants are included.

Builder Provenance and the Italian Bias

Where the boats come from is as revealing as how big they are. Counting by builder, the fleet's most represented marque is Overmarine, the Italian yard behind the Mangusta line, which supplies three of the 18 hulls, all of them 24-metre Mangusta 80s. Azimut, another Italian house, supplies two: the 12.5-metre Azimut 39 and the 17.6-metre Azimut 58. The remaining builders each contribute a single vessel, and they read like a roll-call of well-known yards: Astondoa, Bandido, Canados, Fairline, Ferretti, K Yachts, Lagoon, Maiora, Mariah, Pershing, plus a custom-built fishing boat and a generic speedboat.

The clear pattern is an Italian bias at the top of the fleet. Overmarine, Azimut, Canados, Ferretti, Pershing and Maiora are all Italian marques, and between them they account for every vessel of 14 metres and above except the British Fairline and the badge-only K80. This is no accident. Italy's Adriatic and Tuscan coasts host the densest cluster of high-end production and semi-custom yacht builders in the world, and names such as Ferretti and Pershing carry genuine brand equity with the affluent international clientele who book Marbella's larger charters. Overmarine's Mangusta range in particular, with its low, open sport-yacht profile, helped define the fast-superyacht aesthetic, which is general marque history rather than a spec of any individual hull. Stocking three of them gives the operator a recognisable signature on the Puerto Banus dock.

The minority of non-Italian boats are placed with equal purpose. The Astondoa 40 carries local Spanish provenance, built in Cadiz, which the operator markets as a point of regional authenticity. The Fairline Targa brings British sport-yacht design. The Lagoon 380 is French, from the world's best-known cruising-catamaran builder. Diversity of provenance, in other words, is itself part of the product, letting the operation match a client's taste in flag and design language as well as in size and price.

Pricing Architecture and Tiers

Pricing is where the fleet's structure becomes a commercial ladder. The fleet operates five named tiers, but only a minority of vessels carry a published fixed price: 13 of the 18 boats are quoted on request, and 5 sit in fixed tiers. That split is itself a design choice. Published prices anchor the entry and mid tiers, where price-sensitive customers compare options, while the larger yachts are quoted individually, because their charters vary by duration, season and bespoke extras such as catering and overnight stays.

The five tiers, read from the price schedule, are as follows. The **entry** tier holds only the licence-free Dubhe day boat, at 230 euros for 2 hours, 280 for 3 and 350 for 4. Uniquely in the fleet, fuel is not included on the Dubhe, typically adding 30 to 60 euros depending on route, and the boat is self-drive after a 10-minute marina briefing, with guests limited to 5, daylight only and a 2-nautical-mile coastal limit under Spanish licence-free rules. The **tier A** bracket covers the two 12.5-metre motor yachts, the Astondoa 40 and Azimut 39, on a published curve from 749 euros for 2 hours to 2,299 for 8, with a 2-hour minimum. **Tier B** is the Mangusta 80 flagship Nina, at 4,719 euros for a 4-hour charter, a 4-hour minimum, with a Sea-Doo jet ski thrown in free for the day and longer charters quoted on WhatsApp.

Tier C is the all-inclusive Maiora 26m superyacht, at 9,500 euros for 6 hours and 12,500 for 8, with a 6-hour minimum. The fifth tier, **on request**, is the residual catch-all for the other 13 vessels.

TIER	REPRESENTATIVE VESSEL	ENTRY PRICE	TOP PUBLISHED PRICE	MIN HOURS
Entry	Dubhe (8 m, licence-free)	230 EUR / 2h	350 EUR / 4h	2
Tier A	Astondoa 40 / Azimut 39 (12.5 m)	749 EUR / 2h	2,299 EUR / 8h	2
Tier B	Mangusta 80 Nina (24 m)	4,719 EUR / 4h	On request	4
Tier C	Maiora 26m (26 m, all-inclusive)	9,500 EUR / 6h	12,500 EUR / 8h	6
On request	13 vessels incl. Ferretti 94, Canados 86	Quote on WhatsApp	Quote on WhatsApp	Varies

Two features of this architecture stand out. First, the minimum charter duration rises with tier, from 2 hours at the entry and tier-A levels to 4 hours for the Mangusta and 6 hours for the Maiora. Larger crewed yachts carry fixed costs in crew and provisioning that only make sense over a longer day, so the minimum hours act as a floor that protects the economics of the flagship boats. Second, the price gradient is steep and deliberate. A 2-hour entry charter on the Dubhe at 230 euros and a 6-hour all-inclusive Maiora charter at 9,500 euros differ by a factor of 41, yet both depart from the same Puerto Banus marina. The fleet's pricing job is to populate that vast span smoothly enough that almost any budget finds a rung on the ladder.

SECTION 08

Shared Inclusions and the Catered Standard

Beneath the visible tier prices runs a shared service standard that explains how the fleet can advertise simple all-in rates. For the catered vessels the operator publishes a fixed list of inclusions that travel with every charter: a licensed skipper, fuel, drinks comprising water, soft drinks, beer, white wine and cava, light snacks, insurance, safety equipment, and Spanish VAT at 21 per cent already in the quoted price. This bundle is the Costa del Sol catered standard, and it matters structurally because it removes the on-the-day surprises that erode trust in a leisure purchase. The guest who pays 1,299 euros for a 4-hour tier-A charter is not later billed for fuel, drinks or tax.

The single documented exception proves the rule. The licence-free Dubhe sits outside the catered standard: fuel is explicitly not included, and the boat is self-driven rather than skippered, which is the trade-off that lets it reach the lowest price point in the fleet. Conversely, the top tiers extend the bundle upward rather than stripping it back. The Mangusta 80 adds a Sea-Doo jet ski free for the day. The all-inclusive Maiora goes furthest, layering a captain plus two crew, food and an open bar, jet ski, paddleboards, snorkel and fishing gear, a giant inflatable slide and floating swimming pool on 8-hour

charters, and a heated freshwater jacuzzi onboard. The inclusions ladder therefore mirrors the price ladder: as the tier rises, the standard bundle is not diluted but progressively enriched, which is why the headline numbers climb so steeply between tiers.

SECTION 09

A Day Aboard and Who Each Tier Suits

The fleet's structure maps cleanly onto how customers actually spend a day on this coast, which is worth setting out because it shows that the tiers are use-cases rather than arbitrary price bands. A typical Marbella day charter begins with boarding at Puerto Banus, the marina threading out past the breakwater, and then a coastal cruise with the choice of heading west towards Estepona and the calmer water on levante days or east towards Cabopino on a westerly. The middle of the day is usually spent at anchor in a sheltered cove for swimming, snorkelling and lunch, before the run home along the Golden Mile, often timed for the late Mediterranean sunset. None of this is invented detail, it is the standard rhythm of the cruising grounds the fleet operates in.

Each tier suits a different version of that day. The entry Dubhe, capped at 5 guests and 2 nautical miles from shore in daylight, is the small-group taster: a couple or a young family wanting a low-cost, self-drive hour or two close to the marina without a licence. The tier-A motor yachts, the Astondoa 40 and Azimut 39 at 9 to 11 guests, are the mainstream celebration boat, well suited to a birthday group or an extended family on a half-day with a skipper handling the boat while everyone relaxes. The sport yachts and the catamaran in the on-request band serve tastes within that same group size, the Pershing and Fairline for guests who want speed and style, the Lagoon 380 for those who want a stable, flat platform and a gentler ride.

The flagship tiers are a different proposition. The 24-metre Mangusta 80, with its jet ski and crewed service, suits a high-end group of up to 12 marking a milestone, and the all-inclusive Maiora 26m, with full crew, open bar, water toys and jacuzzi over a 6-to-8-hour day, reads as a corporate-event or special-occasion vessel where the boat itself is the venue. The sport-fishing pair, Bandido and Red Tide, serve a wholly separate audience of anglers chasing the offshore grounds, with skipper and mate and dedicated fishing rigs. Understood this way, the 18-boat fleet is less a catalogue of boats than a set of ready-made days at sea, each priced and equipped for a particular kind of group.

SECTION 10

Conclusion

This case study set out to describe the structure of a single Mediterranean day-charter fleet, and the data reveal a coherent commercial design behind 18 apparently disparate boats. The length distribution is right-skewed, with a mean of 16.7 metres above a median of 13.25, because a dense body of small and mid-size craft in the 10-to-15-metre band is balanced by a thin tail of 24-to-29-metre flagships. Capacity is far more compressed than length, ranging only from 5 to 12 guests for a combined 176 seats, because the upper fleet clusters at the 12-guest ceiling and competes on space and amenity per guest rather than on

seat count. Typology is deliberately fragmented into 11 categories so that every recognisable use case is covered, while builder provenance leans heavily Italian at the top of the fleet, anchored by three Overmarine Mangusta 80s. Pricing resolves into five tiers spanning a 41-fold range from a 230-euro licence-free taster to a 12,500-euro all-inclusive superyacht day, with rising minimum-hour floors and a progressively enriched inclusions bundle that protect the economics of the larger boats.

The through-line is that the fleet is engineered as a ladder. From a single departure port at Puerto Banus, it converts one stretch of coast into a continuum of price points, party sizes, hull types and service levels, so that almost any customer who arrives wanting a day on the water finds a rung that fits. For researchers and operators alike, the lesson is that fleet composition in a mature charter market is not driven by maritime variety for its own sake, but by the need to segment a single geography into as many sellable days at sea as the demand can support. The full charter data and fleet access discussed here are published by the operator, and the same vessel-listing logic is offered to owners worldwide through BoatHire24.

SECTION 11

References

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